Essay for the Department of Drama, Theatre and Dance

This essay requires students to write 2,500 words on a theme explored in a Theatre and Ideas module. Students are assessed on their ability to:

- Describe, interpret, theorise, and evaluate performance texts and events from a range of critical, theoretical, and philosophical perspectives.
- Follow and engage in cross-disciplinary conversations about theatre, theory and philosophy. Coherently develop and express ideas in various media including, but not limited to, essays and reports, creative writing, presentation, meetings, digital and social media, performance.
- Develop skills in research, gathering appropriate evidence and ideas.
- Consider and acknowledge the ways in which race and racism impacts performance cultures and the wider world.

MARKER'S COMMENTS

How did you do?

This essay identifies the key issues raised by the question with insight and is a persuasive, original piece of writing. It is precise and thoughtful in its analysis and critically engages with a wide range of well-chosen secondary literature. It critically assesses its key concepts and the argument is sophisticated, coherent, persuasive, and confident. The essay is written and structured clearly and fluently.

This is a very good essay, with an excellent analysis of the performance work and some very good independent research. You have a wonderful personal voice that weaves through the essay and your writing and it feels strong and assertive. Your focus on Brecht is compelling and well understood, as well as your debate around the line between conceptual art and performance pieces.

How can you do better?

I think your signposting paragraphs (where you discuss the next section and what you will focus on) is really helpful for the reader. However, I would advise working on a more sophisticated way of incorporating this into the text as it feels a little jarring (at one point, a paragraph is just one sentence).

Discuss how artist Yin Xiuzhen's 'Washing the River' has contributed to debates around Environmentalism and the Anthropocene.

CeDAS COMMENTS

Within this essay, I will be discussing the overarching matter of environmentalist debates sparked by artist Yin Xiuzhen's original 1995 performance "Washing of the river". As a guide through my discussion, I will split the argument into two essential parts; how the performance is seen to create negative consequences through the harsh lens of ecocriticism versus the success found through centring anthropocentric ideas. I will consider how Yin Xiuzhen has contributed to environmental activism through the medium of theatre and performative Art and their involvement with political and social change. Consequently, I can begin to theorise specific contributions that make the performative piece a success. For instance, the performative piece's fundamental reliance on audience immersion contributes to an increase (or decrease) in human behavioural change towards our environment.

Detailed plan of how the writer will tackle the essay.

Before delving into the environmental debates sparked by Yin's performance, I will explore the definitions of significant terminology used to help understand the core of my discussion. In doing so, I can begin to expand on the logistics of Xiuzhen's performative piece physically shown to audience members.

Anthropocene is 'viewed as the period during which human activity has been the dominant influence on climate and the environment.' [1]Anthropocene links closely to the fundamentals of Yin's performative Art; she aims to "wake people up, so that they become aware; and to activate their inner hero, so hopefully changes can be made." Yin confronts the

[1] Oxford Languages- Oxford University Press, https://languages.oup.com/google-dictionary-en/ . 2022

negative environmental impact humans have had on this planet by taking the issues to the lead cause themselves (humans), hoping to empower them to change their ways and create a healthier environment. In 1995 she started a politically progressive spectacle, which included having a stack of 162 frozen blocks of polluted water, frozen to ice, assembled from the water of the Funan River in Chengdu, China. The performance lasted two days and involved having audience members take brushes and mops and engaging in the symbolic act of cleansing the polluted water by scrubbing at the ice until it melted and flowed back into the river. The symbolic intent of the performance was to allow participators to contribute 'to undo the damage to nature'.[2] The ecological relevance of artistic and performative rituals was significant when campaigning to bring about political and social change to our polluted planet. Consequently, it has been staged four different times.

Some useful scene setting: the reader is introduced to artist Yin Xiuzhen's environmentalist aims and provided with an overview of her 1995 spectacle.

This section will debate the benefits of audience participation in Yin Xiuzhen's performative art. It will begin to theorise how audience immersion contributes to an increase (or decrease) in human behavioural change concerning Anthropocene and environmental issues.

This might be a case of 'over-signposting' Check this video by RHUL academic, Ursula Hackett.

The philosophical view is that "anthropocentrism can refer to the point of view that humans are the only, or primary, holders of moral standing."[3] I believe Yin Xiuzhen's performative art explores Anthropocentrism with the intent to raise awareness of water pollution caused by humans. It demonstrates the behavioural change that needs to be made by the perpetrators first-hand. Naturally, an environmental discussion is formed

[2] ART SPACE . "Plushy terrorism and cities in suitcases: artist Yin Xiuzhen on how to challenge society with its own refuse" art space editors (translated from chinese by jeff crosby) jan 14, 2017

[3] *Padwe , Jonathan 'Anthropocentrism' Oxford Bibliographies https://www.oxfordbibliographies.com/view/document/obo-9780199830060/obo-9780199830060-0073.xml DOI: 10.1093/OBO/9780199830060-0073 ,26 AUGUST 2013*

when audience members partake in 'cleaning the water'.[4] Whether the debate ignited transforms into a positive or negative outcome, the fundamental matter of raising awareness is executed. My theory is supported by Brecht's ideas on the spectators within a performance. 'It can demand external action and not just provide introspective psychology. The spectator is no longer allowed to spectate or submit to the experience uncritically without practical consequences, i.e. empathy'.[5] Concerning the success of audience participation within Xuizhen's model, as a participant, we are further encouraged that the future is their responsibility by experiencing the action that needs to take place first-hand. As a consequence, the performance provides a way to take environmental action.

Clear discussion of a participatory approach that leads to 'external action'.

'In the world where democracy, activism, and freedom of speech become more and more important values, theatre should not be a place where one is supposed to remain passive and silent and to accept everything that is said.'[6] Yin Xuizhen's performance is successfully supporting the concept of 'theatre becoming a rehearsal space for democracy'.[7] Her artistic work is seen as a platform for open discussion. The participants' intentional freedom does not mean they are forced to change or make a difference, but to be critical, active, and responsible for what is happening'[8]- by consequence, we become enlightened to the power we hold and what we could do. For instance, 'During the first river washing performance in Chengdu, 1995, an onlooker asked Yin if they could take a block of ice

Note: for Drama students, the preferred style is MLA which is a parenthetical (brackets) style. See here.

[4] *Miller, Partricia Dr Jane Chin Davidson 'WASHING THE RIVER IN RELATION TO INTERPELLATION, THEATRICALITY AND SPECTATORSHIP' 17 February 2019*

[5] *Bertolt Brecht, "Theatre for Pleasure or Theatre for Instruction," "Alienation Effects in the Narrative Pictures of the Elder Brueghel," and "On Experimental Theatre," Brecht on Theatre: The Development of an Aesthetic, e d. John Willett, pp. 69-77, 130-6, 157-9. 1964*

[6] *Burzynska, Anna. 'Joined Forces; Audience Participation in Theatre' Published by Alexander Verlag, Berlin(. https://www.alexander-verlag.com/images/verlag/medien/9783895814273-Joined_Forces_-_Performing_Urgency_3_press.pdf)*

[7] *Jacques Rancierre, "The Emancipated Spectator," ArtForum (March, 2007). pp. 272*

[8] *Monica Tan, "Chinese Artist Makes Waves and Ice to Highlight Environmental Pollution," Australia Culture Blog, Dark Mofo (2014)*

home with them to keep their fruit cool and to put in their drinks'.[9] Basing my assumption that the onlooker spoke to others about the spectacle, there continues to be a subconscious contribution to ongoing growth in activism surrounding thoughts on the environmental concern of water pollution. The constant discussion of the sheer volume of polluted water is being bought to people's attention, allowing thought for a change. What's more, this compelling performance piece remains relevant due to the sheer volume of global issues, and the action that still so clearly needs to take place. Yin suggests evidence that "Everyone has to breathe the air and drink the water. And these days, the problem has become very serious, so every person in China is familiar with this issue... Even the government is paying attention."[10] By using theatrical entertainment to fascinate spectators and provoke philosophical and political debates around environmental issues, Yin Xuizhen makes performance a powerful talking point for the Chinese audience.

Yin Xuizhen's performative piece creates a debate on environmentalism through audience immersion and participation. Are the ideas provoked through human interaction successful in creating thought for change to our global issues? Or is the symbolic nature of the piece counterproductive in subjecting the audience to the reflection on environmental concerns? To begin to depict the politics behind Xiuzhen's performance, I will continue to engage in the philosophical side of Yin's Art but provides evidence of how the performance contradicts ecocriticism's values.

This transition paragraph aims to connect the two parts of the essay.

It can be argued that Yin's performance symbolic attitude overlooks the teaching aspect and therefore lacks efficacy in the eyes of ecocriticism. Ecocritical theory and practice can be seen as a literary approach to the

[9] *Monica Tan, "Chinese Artist Makes Waves and Ice to Highlight Environmental Pollution," The Guardian Publication Australia Culture Blog, Dark Mofo (2014)*

[10] *ART SPACE . "PLUSHY TERRORISM AND CITIES IN SUITCASES: ARTIST YIN XIUZHEN ON HOW TO CHALLENGE SOCIETY WITH ITS OWN REFUSE" ART SPACE EDITORS (TRANSLATED FROM CHINESE BY JEFF CROSBY) JAN 14, 2017*

environmental crisis, where the relationship between humans and nature is explored, predominantly centring on nature over man. Ecocritics believe that teaching will make a far more significant change in our environment than through performances. Regarding 'washing the river' where humans are centred on making the change, the efficacy of creating human behavioural change to care for our environment would be less than if it were taught through other mediums. Alan Read presents 'an expanded field' within the means of theatre. 'Theatre, either consciously or unconsciously, has played such a minor role in ecocriticism in comparison to other disciplines such as literature, philosophy, visual art history.'[11] Yin Xuizhen's performance lacks in contributing to the environmental debates bought to the attention of ecocriticism which have become more and more relevant, mirroring the growth of global problems. With theatre relying on the psyche of humans, other disciplines "can do without human beings by turning their attention to the object world, dramatic theatre has'[12] Read maintains that there are far more thought-provoking ways to tackle environmental issues in support of ecocriticism.

Within this section, I will look specifically into the benefits of visual Art.

What if we were to eliminate the participatory element of Yin Xiuzhen's "Washing of the river" performance and her Art solely relies on spectatorship? The performance can now fall under the bracket of Conceptual Art. Could the visual art approach lead to a growth of environmental activism more so than through performative Art? Do the scholarly ways of teaching contribute more to environmental and Anthropocene debates? The understanding that 'In conceptual art, the idea or concept is the most important aspect of the work'[13] Yin Xiuzhen's

Discussion of an alternative approach - moving from participation to spectatorship.

[11] *Read, A 'Theatre In The Expanded Field: Seven Approaches to Performance.' London: Bloomsbury. 2013*

[12] *Read, A. Theatre In The Expanded Field: Seven Approaches to Performance. London: Bloomsbury. 2013*

[13] *LeWitt 'Paragraphs on Conceptual Art', Artforum Vol.5, no. 10, Summer 1967, pp. 79-83*

performance artwork is believed to similarly leave the art to the audience's perspective. This hypothetical situation resonates with an ecocritical postion because nature is now the centre of the piece. Evidence suggests that "Art has long been an important force in environmental movements. In China, environmental Art is a fast-growing sector of the art scene.'[14] As conceptual art, Yin Xuizhen's piece would appeal to more people. We are becoming more successful in generating potential philosophical and political debates around environmental issues. As a further consequence, by eliminating the practical element, the mind concentrates on understanding the duties we have as humans to take responsibility for our actions.

The scholarly teaching aspects of ecocriticism assert that the performative elements take away from the severity of the issues at hand. Granted, it is expected that not everyone will grasp the message of environmental activism. Yet, I argue that reliance on the symbolic aspect will confuse consciously and have a counterproductive effect on changing behaviour due to 'humans being basic creatures we strive for results, not ideas'[15]. Having audience members "pretend" to wash away at pollution seems insincere.

Understanding the spiritual concept of Yin's performance led me to explore the symbolic religious values of how the performance enhances or is counterproductive in understanding the concept of 'washing the river', allowing constant consideration to how both aspects promote debates of environmentalism.

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[14] *Lavery, Carl. 'Introduction: performance and ecology – what can theatre do?' Green Letters 20:3 (2016): 229-236.Note: Please read section titled 'An expanded field' pp.230-233.*

[15] *Bertolt Brecht, "Theatre for Pleasure or Theatre for Instruction," "Alienation Effects in the Narrative Pictures of the Elder Brueghel," and "On Experimental Theatre," Brecht on Theatre: The Development of an Aesthetic, e d. John Willett (NY: Hill and Wang, 1964), pp. 69-77, 130-6, 157-9.*

Suppose we link back to Yin Xiuzhen's objectives for 'washing the river', which was to raise awareness. In that case, the religious aspect of the performative piece could undermine its efficacy in promoting global change.

Despite no evidence of Yin's intent to have specifically Christian connotations, the concept of 'washing away our sins' links closely to the views of evangelical Christians. Within the bible, God says - "Thus you shall do to them to cleanse them: sprinkle the water of purification upon them, and let them go with a razor over all their body, and wash their clothes and cleanse themselves" [16](Numbers 8:7) Isaiah 1:16) the ideas the performance generates a Gods words 'make yourselves clean; remove the evil of your deeds from before my eyes; cease to do evil."[17] Similarly, participants in the spiritual act are removing the 'evil' (the polluted water) to make the change so that the problem can stop. The bible often uses physical illustrations to help us understand spiritual truths. Likewise, Yin's Art uses a visual demonstration of water pollution to help others understand their 'sins'. The religious connection is minimal; to an atheist or non-religious person, the spiritual values taken from the piece hold almost no relevance in delving into a more significant meaning of the performance.

Granted, the actions of washing the block of ice are visually apparent, but as stated previously, 'humans are elemental creatures; we strive for results, not ideas,'[18] so once the water returns to the river, there is no visual change of water pollution decreasing. Therefore, there is a struggle to understand the intent of her performance.

Ecocritical theories state that the success of learning through mediums such as literature, philosophy, visual art (and so forth) is the most effective

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[16] *New Testament, The Bible or the bible hub (Numbers 8:7) Isaiah 1:16) 2004 - 2021*
[17] *New International version, The bible (Isaiah 1:16) 2004 - 2021*
[18] Howe, Cymene, and Pandian, Anand. 'Introduction' to Anthropocene Unseen. New York: Punctum Books, 2019.

way of teaching understanding of our global issues. However, Brecht argues that we are more likely to wan .to be taught through the theatrical medium 'If there were no amusement to be had from learning, then theatre's whole structure would be unfit for teaching'[19]. Through a visual display with added engagement, Yin has created a captivating piece where there is no expectation to partake in the performative art. However, the entertainment value of participation allows a new way of learning, subconsciously or not, by engaging in the piece 'The idea of participation for filling the thought for change more significant than spectatorship.'[20] For this reason, debates on environmental values and talk of Anthropocene continue to provoke discussion.

In conclusion, the journey of my debate has suggested structured ideas as to how Yin Xiuzhen's' Washing of the river' has led to debates on environmentalism and Anthropocene. Uniquely and authentically, she has executed awareness of global issues; this has ignited discussion and inspired plans for behavioural change to help save our planet. Furthermore, through the spectacle of her participatory piece, Yin has engaged the audience members into discussions of our global issues, specifically water pollution in an entertaining way. Through the lens of ecocriticism, evidence can support there is no necessary reliance on the audience participation due to the concept of her art resonating with society. The fine line between conceptual art and a performative piece provokes an audience response to current affairs. To emphasise, she contributes to debates around environmentalism by creating a platform of

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[19] *Bertolt Brecht, "Theatre for Pleasure or Theatre for Instruction," "Alienation Effects in the Narrative Pictures of the Elder Brueghel," and "On Experimental Theatre,"* Brecht on *Theatre: The Development of an Aesthetic, e d. John Willett (NY: Hill and Wang, 1964), pp. 69-77, 130-6, 157-9.*

[20] *Miller, Partricia Dr Jane Chin Davidson 'WASHING THE RIVER IN RELATION TO INTERPELLATION, THEATRICALITY AND SPECTATORSHIP' 17 February 2019*

'theatre becoming a rehearsal space for democracy'[21] and creating an open-minded and judgement-free place for discussion. She has shown there is not a necessary reliance on audience participation, and the contributing effects can have high efficacy through spectatorship and the concept of her art. Yin's attitude towards society's perspective of the piece allows an open-minded response. Her contribution to begin the debates was' Pragmatically microscopic, but the ambition is scaleless'.[22] As a society Yin's concept taken from Yin's art aids society in progressively understanding environmental matters, further suggesting we are the dictators of growth in behavioural change.

The writer re-visits issues discussed in the essay and provides a clear concluding statement.

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Referencing conventions take time to learn. See here for guidance on how to set out a bibliography using MLA.

[21] *Jacques Rancierre, "The Emancipated Spectator," ArtForum (March, 2007). pp. 272*

[22] *Chang , Aimee 'How Latitudes become Forms; Art in a global age' Courtesy Prüss & Ochs Gallery, Berlin, former Asian Fine 2002 (http://latitudes.walkerart.org/artists/indexbc58.html)*

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